# The Ballot or the Bullet

*Malcolm X · Cleveland, OH (April 3, 1964) & Detroit (April 12, 1964) · excerpts*

*Source: Reprinted in Malcolm X Speaks: Selected Speeches and Statements (ed. George Breitman, 1965).*

Three weeks after breaking with the Nation of Islam, Malcolm X delivered this speech in Cleveland and again in Detroit. He framed 1964 as a watershed election year and argued that Black Americans had to use either the ballot or, failing that, the bullet — the right of self-defense. The speech marked Malcolm's pivot from Nation-of-Islam separatism toward broader Black nationalism and the international human-rights frame he would develop in the months before his assassination in February 1965.

*Connect: Malcolm X's rejection of nonviolence echoes David Walker's 1829 Appeal (Class 19) — both Black leaders argued for self-defense. What continues, and what has changed?*

## Key Passages

### The diagnosis

> I'm not a politician, not even a student of politics; in fact, I'm not a student of much of anything. I'm not a Democrat. I'm not a Republican, and I don't even consider myself an American. … No, I'm not an American. I'm one of the 22 million Black people who are the victims of Americanism.

### Ballot or bullet

> 1964 threatens to be the most explosive year America has ever witnessed. … It's the year when all of the white political crooks will be right back in your and my community … trying to bamboozle you and me. … It'll be the ballot or it'll be the bullet.

### On self-defense

> I don't even call it violence when it's self-defense, I call it intelligence.

### On nonviolence

> Concerning nonviolence: it is criminal to teach a man not to defend himself when he is the constant victim of brutal attacks.

## HAPP Analysis

*Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.*

| HAPP Element | Your Analysis |
|---|---|
| ***Historical Context*** *What was happening when this was written?* | 1964: the Civil Rights Act was stalled by a Senate filibuster, frustration with slow progress was growing, and Malcolm X had just left the Nation of Islam. |
| ***Intended Audience*** *Who was the source written for?* | Black Americans in Northern cities, especially those frustrated with nonviolence; the speeches were given in churches in Cleveland and Detroit. |
| ***Point of View*** *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?* | Malcolm X, a Black nationalist leader who emphasized self-defense and Black political power, and who saw white liberals and politicians as unreliable. |

| HAPP Element | Your Analysis |
| --- | --- |
| ***Purpose***<br>*What did the author want to accomplish?* | |

## Analysis Prompts

**1.** SAQ — compare branches of the CRM: Identify ONE significant similarity AND ONE difference between Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr. in 1964.

**2.** What does Malcolm X mean by saying he is 'not an American'?

**3.** How did Malcolm's views shift in the year between this speech and his assassination?